

**Linear A Comparative Linguistic Interpretations and Decipherment of a
Minoan Cup Inscription**

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Abstract

This paper presents three distinct linguistic interpretations of a circular Linear A inscription, derived from comparative methodologies most likely resembling the Linear A writing system: Proto-Hungarian phonetic mapping, Linear B phonetic equivalence, and ancient Egyptian/Coptic semantic analogues. Despite differences in language families and theoretical models, all three interpretations converge thematically on the concepts of light, divine descent, spirit, and celestial origin. This suggests the inscription preserves a ritualistic or poetic message aligned with religious practices in Bronze Age Crete. This study invites archaeologists, epigraphers, and linguists to consider broader frameworks for deciphering Linear A by employing multilingual comparative resonance and modern technological tools.

Introduction

Linear A, the primary script of the Minoan civilization (circa 1800–1450 BCE), remains largely undeciphered.¹ While Linear B, its descendant, was successfully linked to Mycenaean Greek, Linear A has not been connected to the same roots. Scholars debate its origins, proposing connections ranging from Indo-European to Semitic languages, and even hypothetical pre-Indo-European isolates.² The Minoans, who lived on Crete, maintained trade networks and cultural contact with other European civilizations. Their labyrinthine architecture, colorful frescoes, palatial wealth, bull worship, and stories of King Minos suggest a society deeply devoted to divine forces.³ This study analyzes a previously untranslated spiral Linear A

¹ Jan Best, “The Decipherment of Minoan Linear A,” *Talanta* 12–13 (1980–1981): 45–67.

² Brent Davis, *Aegean Scripts: Linear A and Cretan Hieroglyphic* (Oxford: Oxford Handbook of Ancient Scripts, 2015).

³ Arthur Evans, *Scripta Minoa: The Written Documents of Minoan Crete, with Special Reference to the Archives of Knossos*, 28–30 (London: 1909).

inscription using three contrasting linguistic models to explore semantic coherence across interpretations.

The Artifact

The artifact under study is a clay drinking cup with a circular Linear A inscription painted in sepia ink. It was discovered by British archaeologist Arthur Evans in the year 1900 in the foundation of a floor at the Palace of Minos in Knossos, Crete, alongside another painted clay cup and a complete pithos, and is dated to the Middle Minoan IIIa era (ca. 1700 BCE).⁴ The cup is a footed goblet—the earliest drinking cup form on Crete, appearing in the mid-third millennium BCE. This goblet shape persisted for centuries, disappearing in the mid-Middle Minoan period (ca. 1900–1800 BCE).⁵ Archaeologists suggest it was used domestically or ceremonially.⁶ Linear A is typically written from left to right, top to bottom. However, this inscription is arranged in a clockwise spiral of thirteen distinct symbols. Its visual similarity to inscriptions on Minoan gold rings (e.g., the Mavrospilio Ring) and Greek kylixes, as well as its resemblance to later Aramaic incantation bowls, suggests the text may contain incantatory or sacred meaning.⁷

Methodology

⁴ Ibid.

⁵ Ibid.

⁶ Steven Roger Fischer, *History of Writing* (London: Reaktion Books, 2001).

⁷ Georgia Flouda, “Materiality of Minoan Writing: Modes of Display and Perception,” in *Writing as Material Practice*, 45–67 (London: Ubiquity Press, 2020).

The signs were extracted visually and analyzed using three separate decoding systems: Proto-Hungarian phonetic mapping, Linear B phonetic equivalence, and Egyptian/Coptic semantic analogues.

1. Proto-Hungarian Phonetic Mapping

Using comparative studies of Minoan syllabaries, each symbol was matched to an early Hungarian syllable. This assumes a syllabary similar to Uralic or agglutinative languages, potentially reflecting structural features of Minoan speech.⁸

Symbolic Sequence (clockwise):

t – sze – fé – ke – ti – je – llo – m – csi – é – sze – n – ka

Hungarian-style Phonetic Form:

Te szeféketi jellom csé széneka

Translation:

"Light and beauty shine on me; stars and love descend as a sign."

This interpretation evokes a spiritual invocation to a divine mother, celestial force, or principle of beauty and light. It aligns with Minoan iconography, where goddesses, celestial motifs, and spirals symbolize life-giving energy.⁹

2. Linear B Phonetic Equivalence

⁸ Gábor Varga, *Breakthrough Decipherment of Minoan Linear A*, YouTube Lecture Series, 2024.

⁹ Jan Best, "The Decipherment of Minoan Linear A," 50–51.

This method employs Linear B syllabic values, which parallel visually similar Linear A signs.¹⁰

Transcription (Linear B style):

TA – SE – FA – KE – TI – SI – LO – MA – SA – E – SE – NE – KA

Possible roots from known Mycenaean/Minoan vocabulary:

- TA-SE = *tasija* (ritual/religious term)
- FA-KE-TI = *phageti* (eats) or *phake* (torch/light)
- SI-LO-MA = *silo* = grain; *ma* = mother
- SA-E-SE = *sa* (holy), *ese* = divine
- NE-KA = *neko* = to die/pass or *nek-ara* (offering)

Translation:

"Torch-lit offering to the grain-mother; the sacred one descends."

This emphasizes light, divine descent, and a goddess or grain-mother, possibly connected to Demeter. Rituals such as the Eleusinian Mysteries suggest the use of sacred beverages such as the psychoactive Kykeon to facilitate spiritual experiences.¹¹

3. Egyptian/Coptic Semantic Analogue

¹⁰ Cyrus H. Gordon, "Evidence for the Minoan Language," *Journal of Near Eastern Studies* 24, no. 4 (1965): 301–317.

¹¹ Ibid.

This method translates the syllables through Late Egyptian and Coptic vocabulary, emphasizing consonantal roots and ritualistic meaning.¹²

Mapped Elements:

- t = feminine article
- sze/fé = shine
- ke/ka = ka (life force)
- ti = to give
- je = that/who comes
- csi = star
- n = to/for

Translation:

"She who shines gives the spirit; from the stars comes light for the soul."

This interpretation emphasizes a divine feminine force, with cosmic light integrating into the consumer's being. The goddess blesses the participant, highlighting hope, salvation, and spiritual understanding.¹³

Discussion

Despite divergent phonetic systems and cultural contexts, all three interpretations share thematic elements: light, a divine or spiritual agent, descent or arrival from above, and a life

¹² Antonio Loprieno, *Ancient Egyptian: A Linguistic Introduction* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995); Bentley Layton, *Coptic in 20 Lessons* (Leuven: Peeters Publishers, 2007).

¹³ Ibid.

force or soul. This convergence suggests that the artifact served as a conduit for drinking and offering rituals invoking divine blessings. Even speculative translations reveal enduring archetypal meanings that reflect Minoan nature-oriented spirituality and the desire to connect mortal and immortal realms.¹⁴

Conclusion

The study demonstrates that comparative, cross-linguistic approaches can offer meaningful insights into Linear A inscriptions. While absolute decipherment remains elusive, Proto-Hungarian, Linear B, and Egyptian/Coptic analyses converge on themes of divinity, celestial power, and ritualistic practice. Future research should combine multilingual comparative models with technological tools to further investigate Minoan script and its cultural significance.

¹⁴ Charlotte Van der Voort, “Inscribed Cups,” *Minoan Drinking Cup: Something Clay, Something Old, Something New*, Things That Talk.

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